Mahabalipuram: The Shore Temple City

Introduction to Mahabalipuram

Mahabalipuram, also known as Mamallapuram, is an ancient port town and one of the most famous heritage sites of Tamil Nadu. It lies on the Coromandel Coast of the Bay of Bengal in Chengalpattu district, about 55 to 60 kilometres south of Chennai, along the East Coast Road. The town is renowned for its rock-cut caves, monolithic temples carved from single rocks, open-air bas-reliefs and a magnificent temple standing beside the sea. Together these monuments show the early development of Dravidian architecture and sculpture. European sailors in the past called the place the "Seven Pagodas", from the group of temples they saw from the sea. Mahabalipuram is a major tourist destination and a centre of stone-carving crafts, and the Group of Monuments at Mahabalipuram is a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Which Dynasty Built Mahabalipuram's Monuments?

The monuments of Mahabalipuram were built by the Pallava dynasty, which ruled much of present-day Tamil Nadu and southern Andhra Pradesh from their capital at Kanchipuram between roughly the 3rd and 9th centuries CE. The main building activity took place in the 7th and 8th centuries. King Mahendravarman I (about 600 to 630 CE) began the tradition of rock-cut cave temples in the region. His son, Narasimhavarman I, who was called Mamalla, meaning "great wrestler" (about 630 to 668 CE), developed the port city and carved the monolithic rathas and many of the reliefs; the town is named Mamallapuram in his honour. He defeated the Chalukya king Pulakeshin II and captured Vatapi (Badami) in 642 CE. The Shore Temple was built later during the reign of Narasimhavarman II, called Rajasimha (about 700 to 728 CE), who also built the Kailasanathar Temple at Kanchipuram. Mahabalipuram served as the principal seaport of the Pallavas and was a gateway for trade and cultural contact with Southeast Asia, and the Pallava script and art influenced Southeast Asian kingdoms such as Cambodia and Java.

Monuments of Mahabalipuram

The monuments can be grouped into rock-cut caves (mandapas), monolithic rathas, open-air rock reliefs and structural temples.

The Shore Temple is a structural temple built of granite blocks, standing on the shore of the Bay of Bengal. It has two main shrines dedicated to Lord Shiva, one facing east toward the sunrise and the other facing west, and a smaller shrine of Lord Vishnu reclining in between. The towering pyramidal vimana, about 18 metres tall, and the lines of sculpted Nandi bulls on the walls make it a masterpiece. It is one of the oldest structural stone temples in South India, and the salt air and wind have weathered the carvings. During the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami, the sea drew

back and revealed ancient submerged structures near the shore, and the Shore Temple survived the waves. It is often said that there were once seven temples along the shore, and that six were submerged.

The Pancha Rathas, also called the Five Rathas, are five monolithic temple-like structures carved from single large granite boulders, named after the five Pandava brothers and their wife Draupadi: Dharmaraja Ratha, Bhima Ratha, Arjuna Ratha, Nakula-Sahadeva Ratha and Draupadi Ratha. They were carved from the top downwards and were never completed or used for worship. Next to them are life-sized sculptures of an elephant, a lion and the bull Nandi. These rathas are believed to be prototypes for later temple architecture across India.

Other monuments include the Krishna Mandapa, the Varaha Cave Temple, the Mahishasuramardini Cave with a famous relief of the goddess Durga fighting the buffalo demon, the Trimurti Cave, the Tiger Cave at Saluvankuppam, the Old Lighthouse, and Krishna's Butter Ball, a giant boulder that seems to balance on a slope.

What Is Arjuna's Penance?

Arjuna's Penance, also called the Descent of the Ganga, is a huge open-air bas-relief carved on two enormous boulders of granite, measuring about 30 metres in length and 12 metres in height, one of the largest rock reliefs in the world. It carries more than 100 figures of gods, goddesses, celestial beings, humans and animals, including life-size elephants, deer, monkeys, lions and a cat doing penance. A natural cleft in the rock, which once carried water, represents the River Ganga coming down from heaven. The scene is interpreted in two ways: as the penance of Arjuna, the Pandava hero, who stands on one leg doing severe penance to Lord Shiva to receive the powerful weapon Pashupatastra, or as the story of King Bhagiratha praying to Shiva to bring the River Ganga down to Earth to liberate his ancestors. Experts disagree on which is meant, and it may combine both. The carving dates from the 7th century, in the reign of Narasimhavarman I.

When Did It Become a UNESCO Site?

The Group of Monuments at Mahabalipuram was inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1984, at the eighth session of the World Heritage Committee, among the early Indian sites. It was among the early Indian cultural sites to be listed, and the Sun Temple at Konark in Odisha was also inscribed in 1984. The monuments are protected and maintained by the Archaeological Survey of India. UNESCO recognises the site for its outstanding rock-cut architecture and sculpture of the Pallava period.

Mahabalipuram Today

Mahabalipuram is known for its stone-carving industry; the Government College of Architecture and Sculpture, founded in 1957, trains artisans in traditional temple sculpture. The annual Mamallapuram Dance Festival, held in January and February in front of Arjuna's Penance, features classical dance performances. In October 2019, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping held an informal summit at Mahabalipuram, which brought the town worldwide attention. In July and August 2022 the 44th Chess Olympiad was held there, the first time India hosted the event, and the town was decorated with chess-themed art. Beaches, the East Coast Road and nearby sites such as the Crocodile Bank, Dakshinachitra and the Tiger Cave attract visitors.

Challenges and Future

The monuments face challenges from coastal erosion, salt-laden air, tourist crowds, pollution and rising sea level. The Archaeological Survey of India is carrying out conservation, and underwater archaeology is being used to explore possible submerged structures. Visitors are asked to respect the monuments.

Quick Facts

- The Pallava dynasty built Mahabalipuram, mainly under Narasimhavarman I (Mamalla) and Narasimhavarman II (Rajasimha).
- Arjuna's Penance is a huge rock relief about 30 metres long and 12 metres high with over 100 figures.
- The Group of Monuments at Mahabalipuram became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1984.
- The Shore Temple was built in the early 8th century and stands beside the Bay of Bengal.
- The Pancha Rathas are five monolithic temples named after the Pandavas and Draupadi.